

CHAPTER 1 OF 13 • PART ZERO

Before Anything, a Tuesday

One engineer, wake to sleep. Ten ideas run through her day, and not one of them gets a name until the next chapter.



Thirteen chapters, gathered into six movements.

→ **A Tuesday — one engineer, wake to sleep**

02 The words — naming what you just watched

03 Protagonist and antagonist — where a design starts

04 Solution types — which answer is wanted

05 Six kits — data, compute, network, scale, reliability, security

06 Two designs, then the map back — Instagram, a parking app, and what you keep

WHERE THIS SITS

Read this chapter without looking anything up.

Thirteen chapters carry one method: watch a system, name its parts, cast a design, pick the rung, reach into six kits, then design two products end to end. This first chapter spends no systems-design vocabulary on purpose. You meet each idea the way Maya meets it, against a timestamp, and chapter two hands you the word for it afterwards. Nothing here needs a chapter before it.

PART ZERO

Before anything is a
system, it is a Tuesday.

THE RULES OF THIS PART

Maya has been an engineer for seven months. Today she wants one thing.

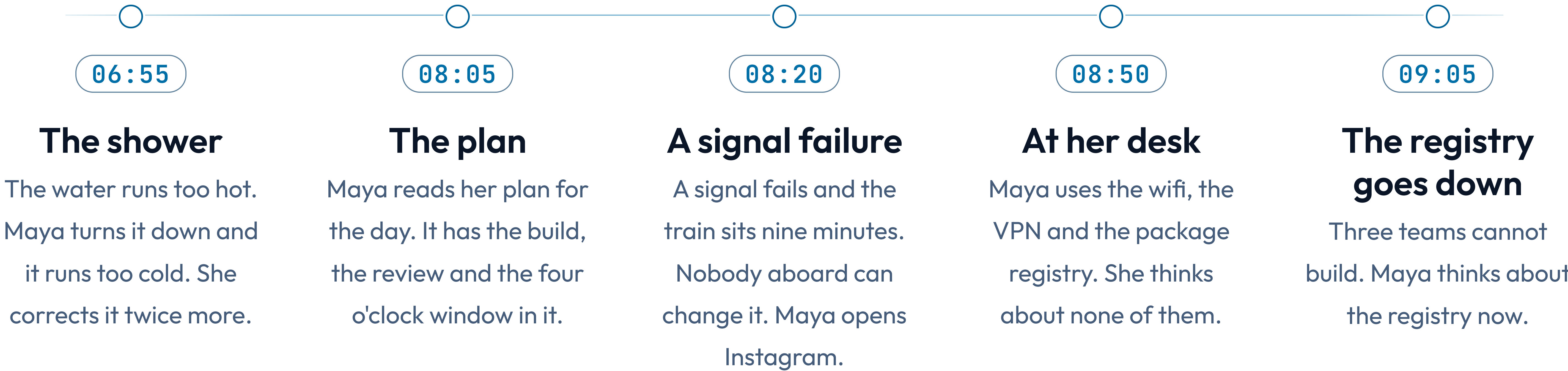
She wants pull request 482 merged before the release window closes at four o'clock.

Watch her Tuesday. This part uses no systems-design words on purpose.

Everything Part one names happens here first, so you see each idea before you have a word for it.

MORNING

Five things happen to Maya before she reaches her desk.



09:15 • STANDUP

Four people met twice this week, and only one meeting worked.

On Monday each person reported to the manager in turn. That meeting ran twenty minutes and settled nothing. Today they talked to each other instead, and Maya learned in one sentence that Priya had already read the code she was about to start.

The four people did not change. Only who talked to whom changed.

Get 482 merged before the window closes.

MAYA WROTE THIS ON A STICKY NOTE AT 09:30. NOTHING ELSE IS WRITTEN ON IT.

09:45 • IN THE WAY

Four limits shape Maya's day, and she chose none of them.

The build takes twelve minutes

Every push costs twelve minutes. Maya cannot shorten that or skip it.

The team is three people

Nobody on the team is free to review her code this morning.

The one reviewer is asleep

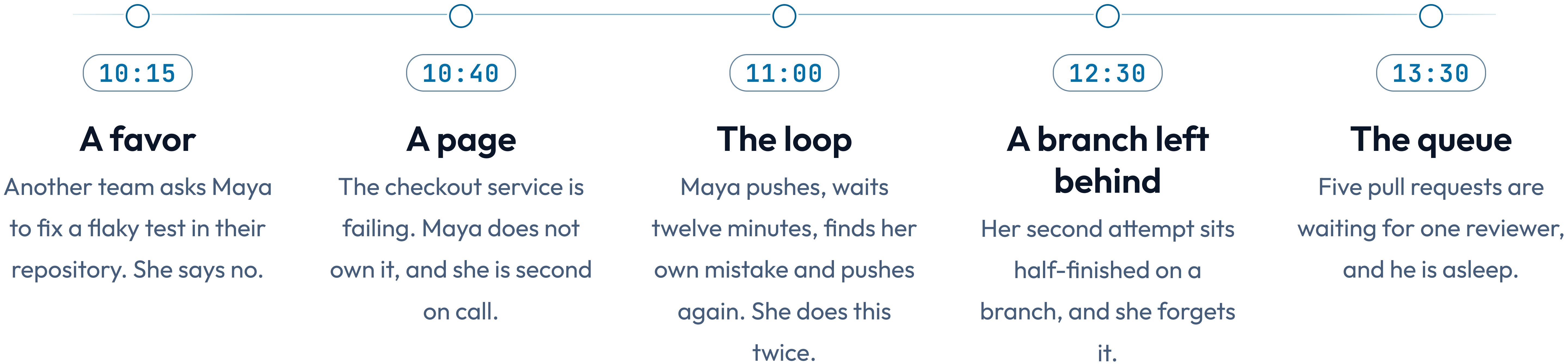
He is six time zones away and will not read anything before three o'clock.

Production data stays in production

She may not copy it to her laptop, even to reproduce the bug.

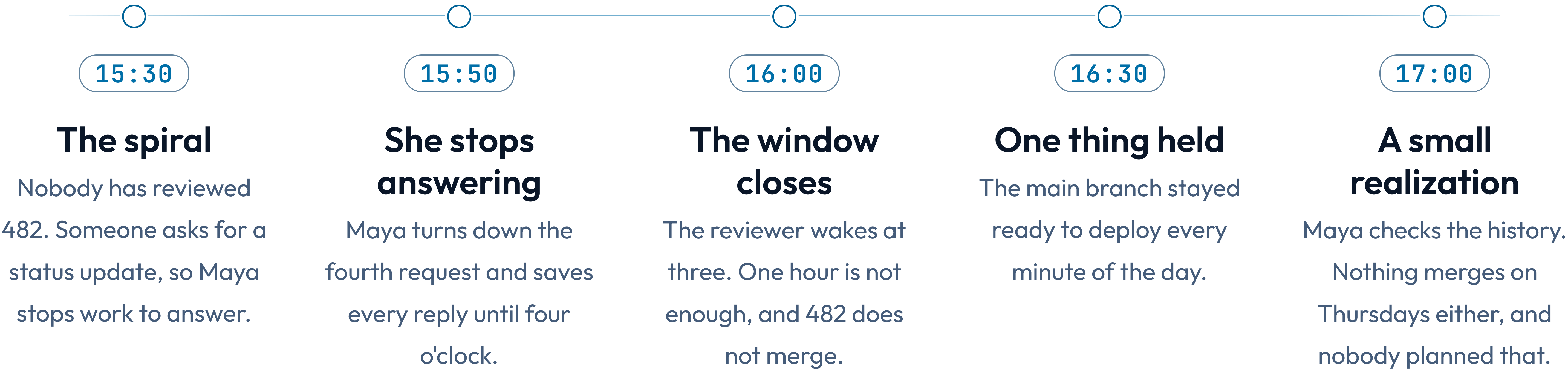
MIDDAY

By lunchtime, other people decide what Maya works on.



AFTERNOON

Maya spends the afternoon answering questions about the work she is not doing.



You just watched a system run for sixteen hours.

Her day had a purpose it did not meet, and one hour that decided it. Two things ran in circles: the shower, and the questions about 482. Something she never thinks about held the day up until the registry stopped at nine. And main stayed deployable throughout — the one promise that held.

The reviewer woke at three and the window shut at four. Everything Maya did that day reached the outcome only through that hour. She spent twenty of its sixty minutes answering questions about 482, instead of waiting ready to act on whatever came back.

Ten ideas ran through that day. Part one gives you the words for them.

CHAPTER 1 OF 13 • HOW TO THINK ABOUT SYSTEMS

Ten ideas ran through that day, unnamed.

*Chapter two names them — system, purpose,
boundary, environment, process, model, constraint,
invariant, infrastructure, emergence — each
against the moment in her day that taught it.*

